SREEJA AKULA, 24

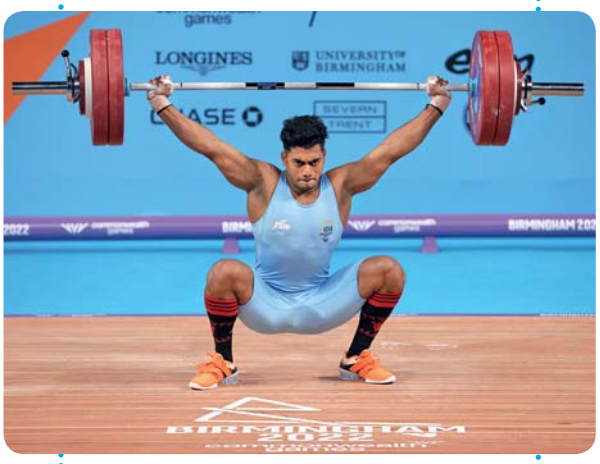
Table Tennis (Mixed doubles with Sharath K. Achanta), GOLD

Paddle Power

Sreeja Akula, the current women's singles national champion, showed her flair and grit as she pushed the first seed and eventual winner Feng Tianwei to seven sets in the semi-final and then narrowly lost the bronze medal tie. Akula, though, didn't return empty-handed from Birmingham. She teamed up with her idol and table tennis royalty Sharath Kamal Achanta or 'Sharath *bhaiya*' as she calls him to win the mixed doubles gold. This was the duo's first tournament together, which makes the feat all the more impressive.

A Hyderabad native, Akula picked up the paddle at the age of nine, drawn to the sport courtesy her father, also a TT player, and sister. Her immediate target now is to carry the momentum to coming international tournaments, improve her world ranking (she's now No. 76) and qualify for the 2024 Paris Olympics. *—SS*





ACHINTA SHEULI, 20

Weightlifting (73 kg), GOLD

Unwavering Focus

Achinta and brother Alok were preparing for the Junior Nationals in 2013 when tragedy struck—their father, a rickshaw puller, died. Alok gave up his dream to be a weightlifter and left college to take a part-time job to keep the household running. "It was the end of my weightlifting career but I was determined not to let my brother give up his passion," says Alok. There were many days when the family of three had to make do with very little, but Achinta never let his focus waver. At the 2013 Guwahati Sub-Junior Nationals, Achinta came in fourth, but his skills drew the attention of officials at the Army Sports Training Institute. He joined the institute in 2014 and there has been no looking back since. A silver at the Youth Commonwealth Games in Pune, a junior world championship and a junior Asia Championship medal followed. In Birmingham, he lifted a record 313 kg (143 kg in snatch and 170 kg in clean and jerk) to win gold. Back home in Bengal, he says he savoured victory with the mutton-rice his mother makes.

–Romita Datta